Group 4

Chapter 9 & Consensus (§ 5)

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9.2 Pollution, Sustainability, and Climatic Change

the mainstream public environmental agenda

Why should publics care the birds sing or not

Why is it bad?

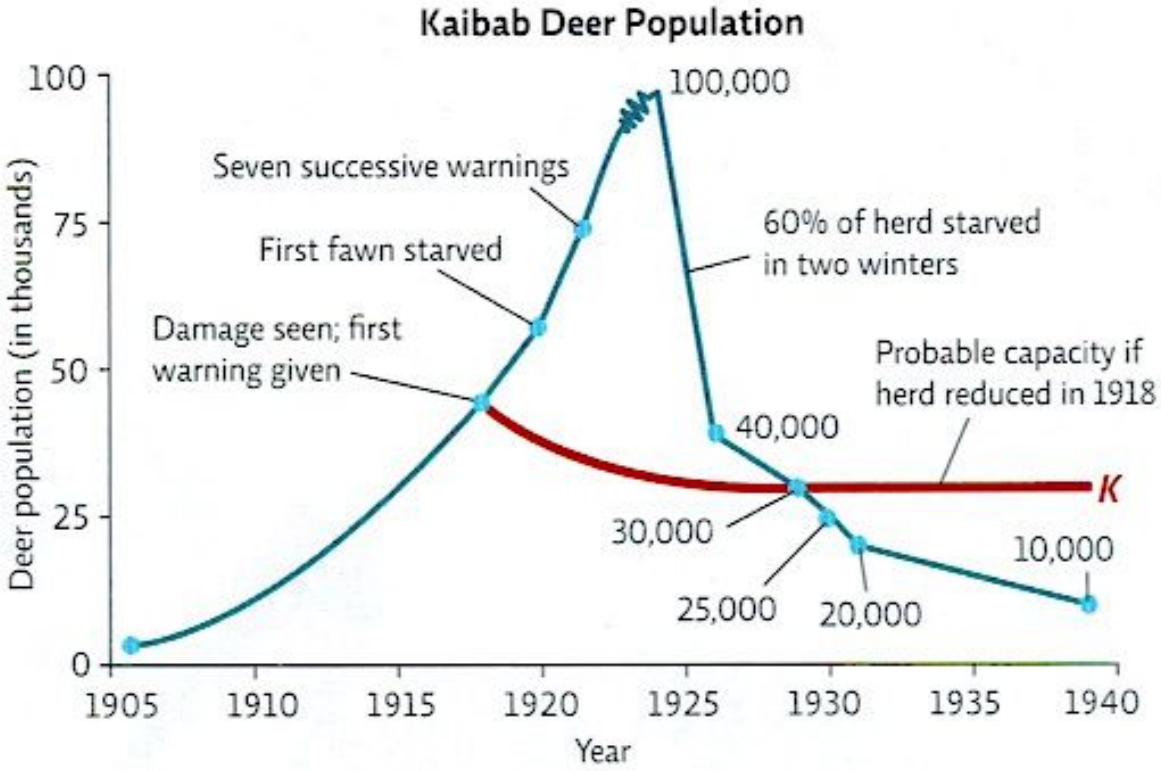
Birds is now non existent

No bird is suffering

Biological interdependence

We can’t only hurt birds

Kaibab deer incident



Why should publics care the birds sing or not

Why is it bad?

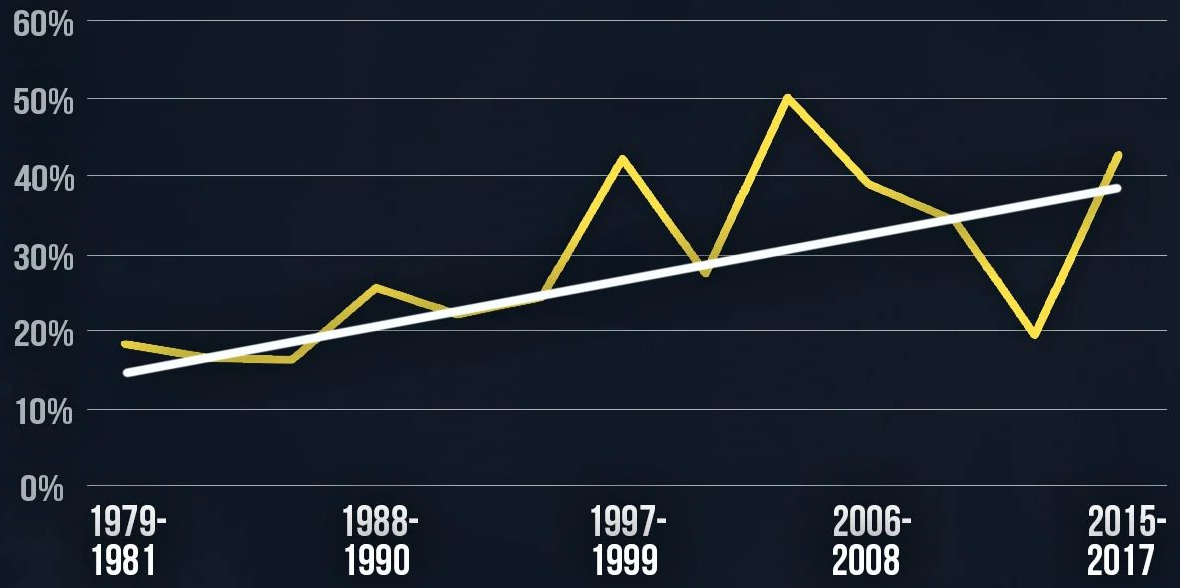
Global significance

It matters to us all

ATLANTIC HURRICANES

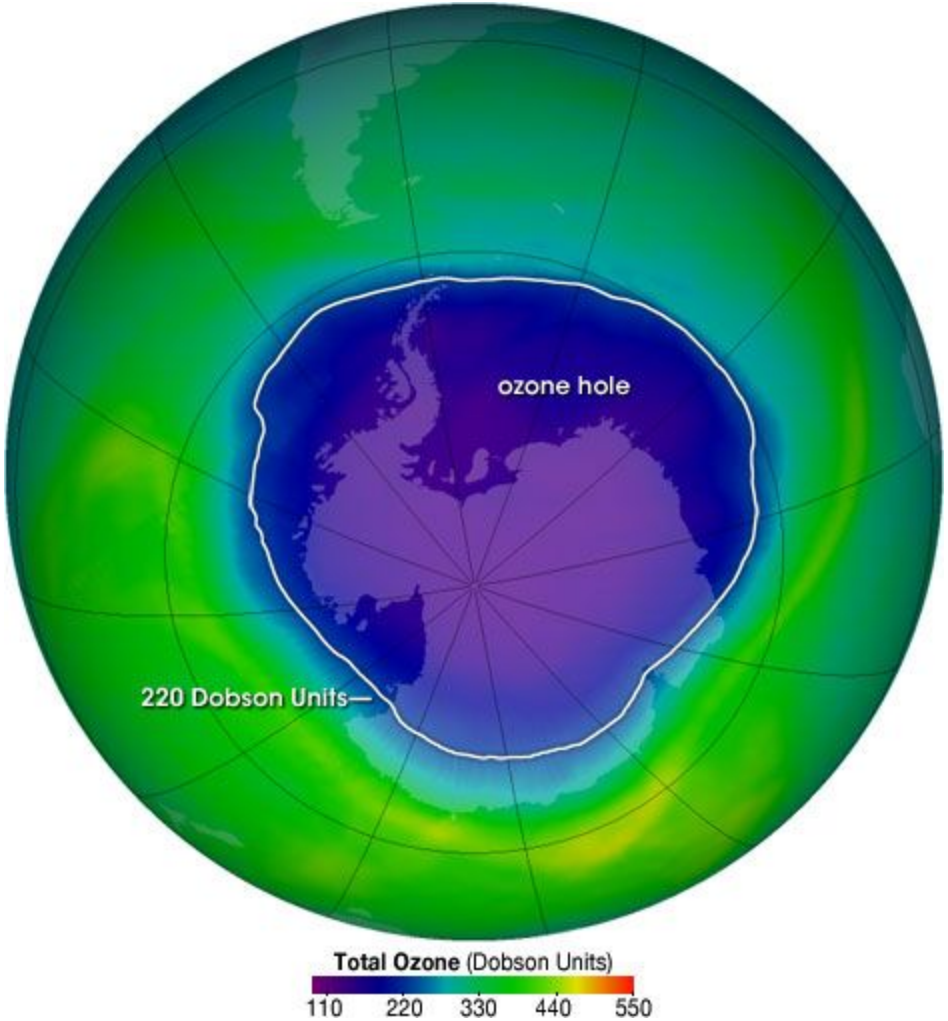
GETTING STRONGER

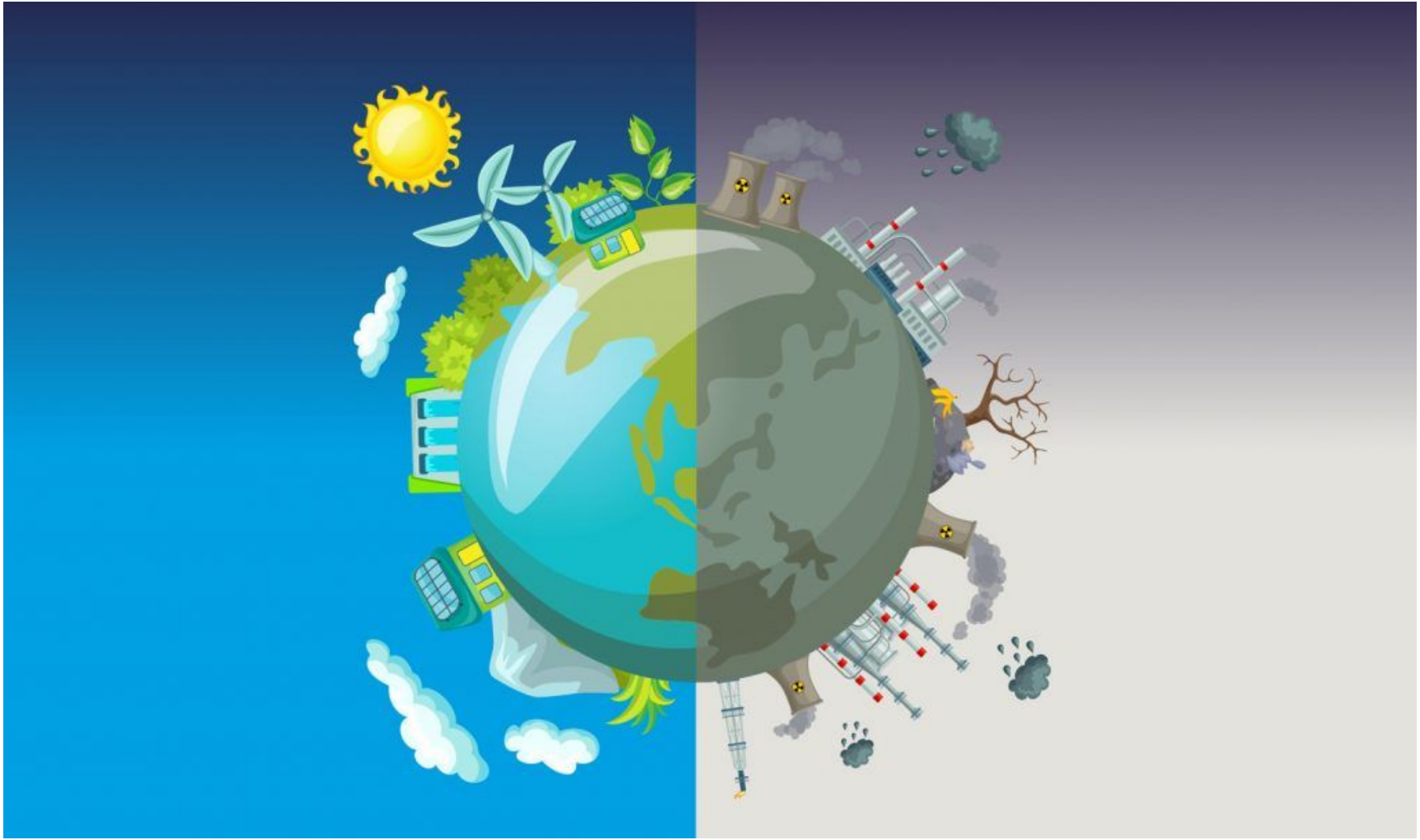
PERCENT OF ALL HURRICANES AS MAJOR STORMS



Based on 6-hour observations for major tropical cyclones (Cat 3-5 compared to all Cat 1+ tropical cyclones). Data collected into 3-year periods.
Source: Kossin et al. (2020)

CLIMATE CENTRAL


ozone hole
220 Dobson Units—
Total Ozone (Dobson Units)
110
220
330
440
550



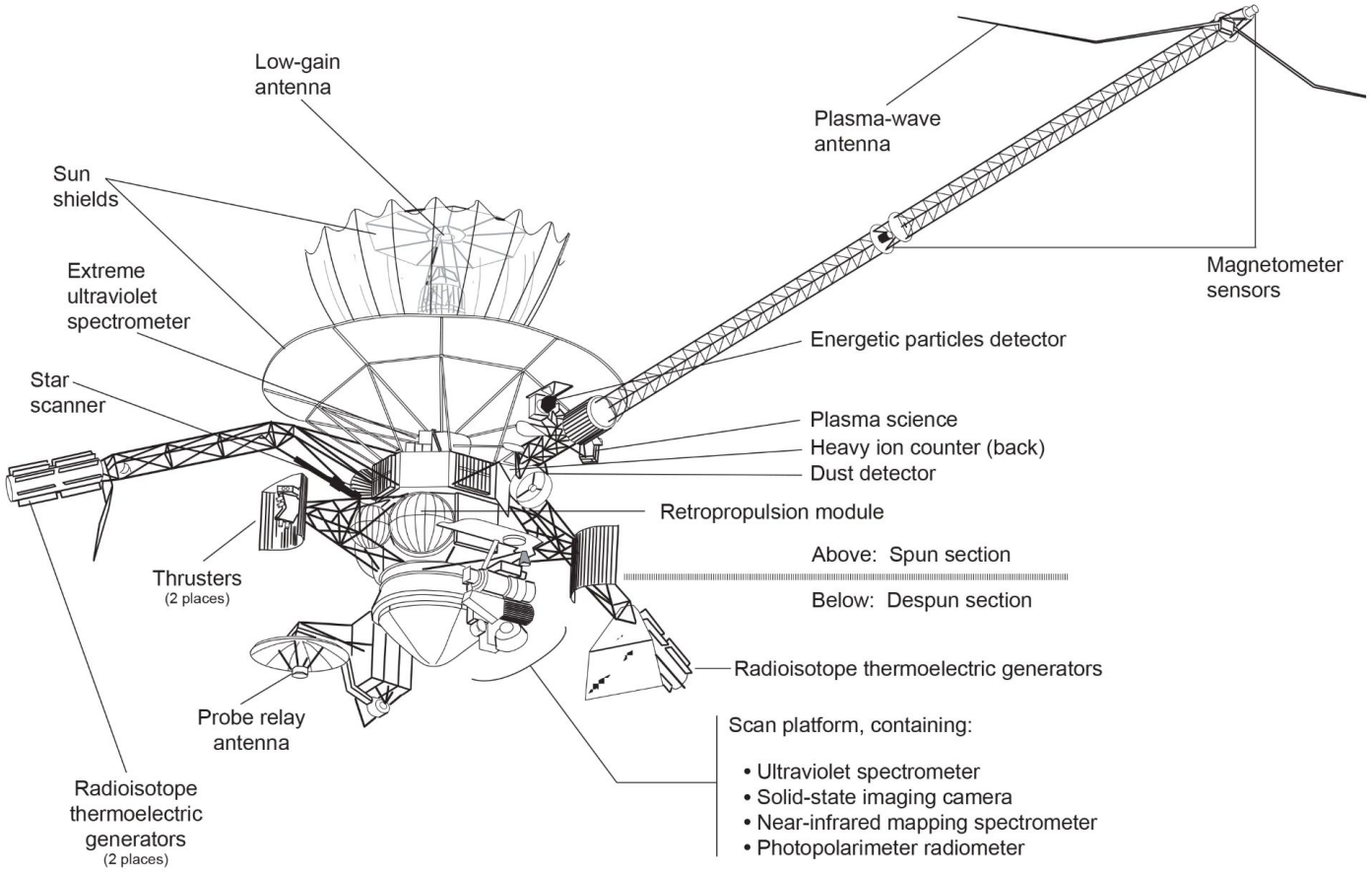
Human centered

People is the one that matters

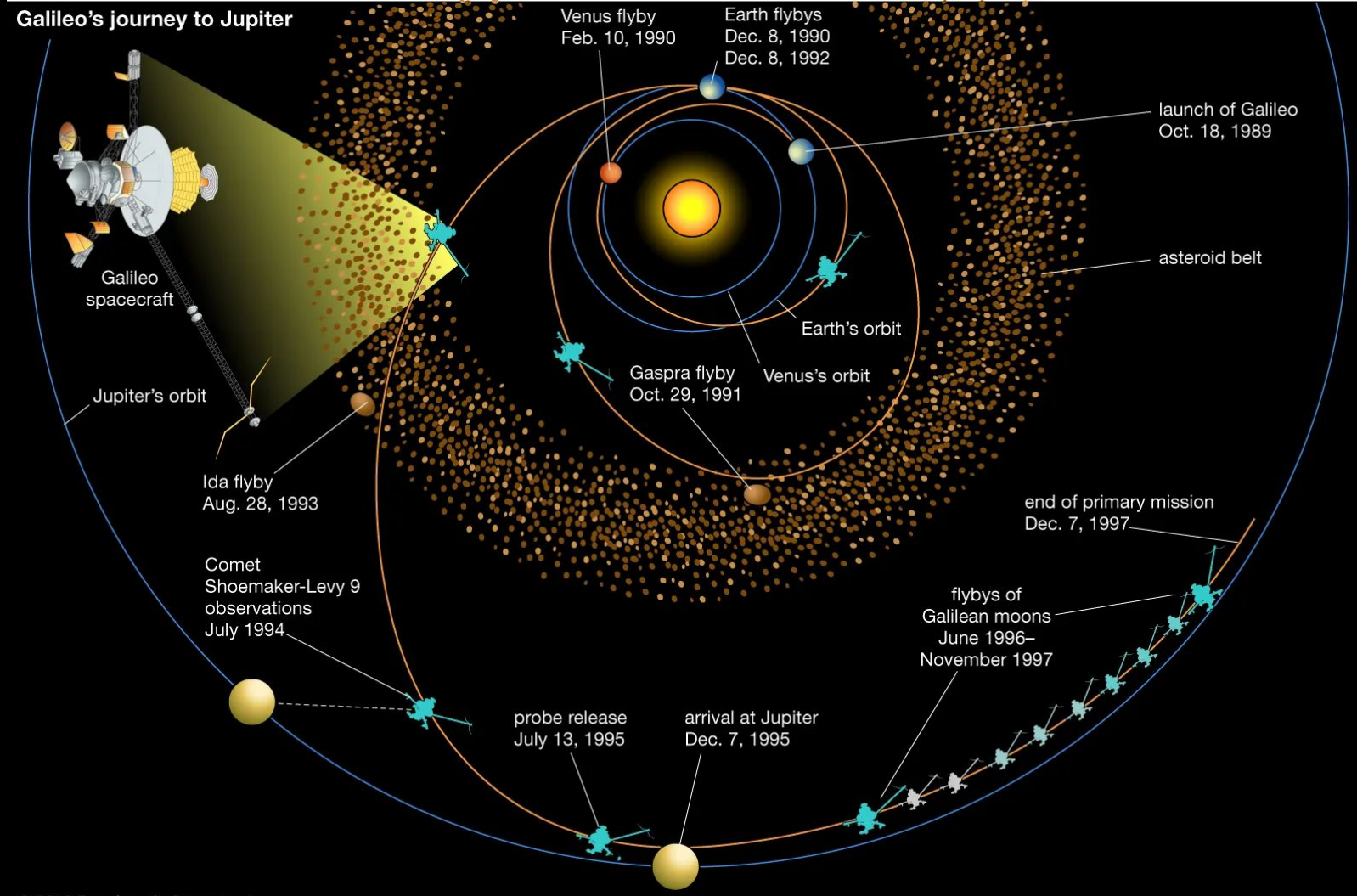
Andromeda

Longtermism

Let’s consider for our descendants.



Galileo spacecraft



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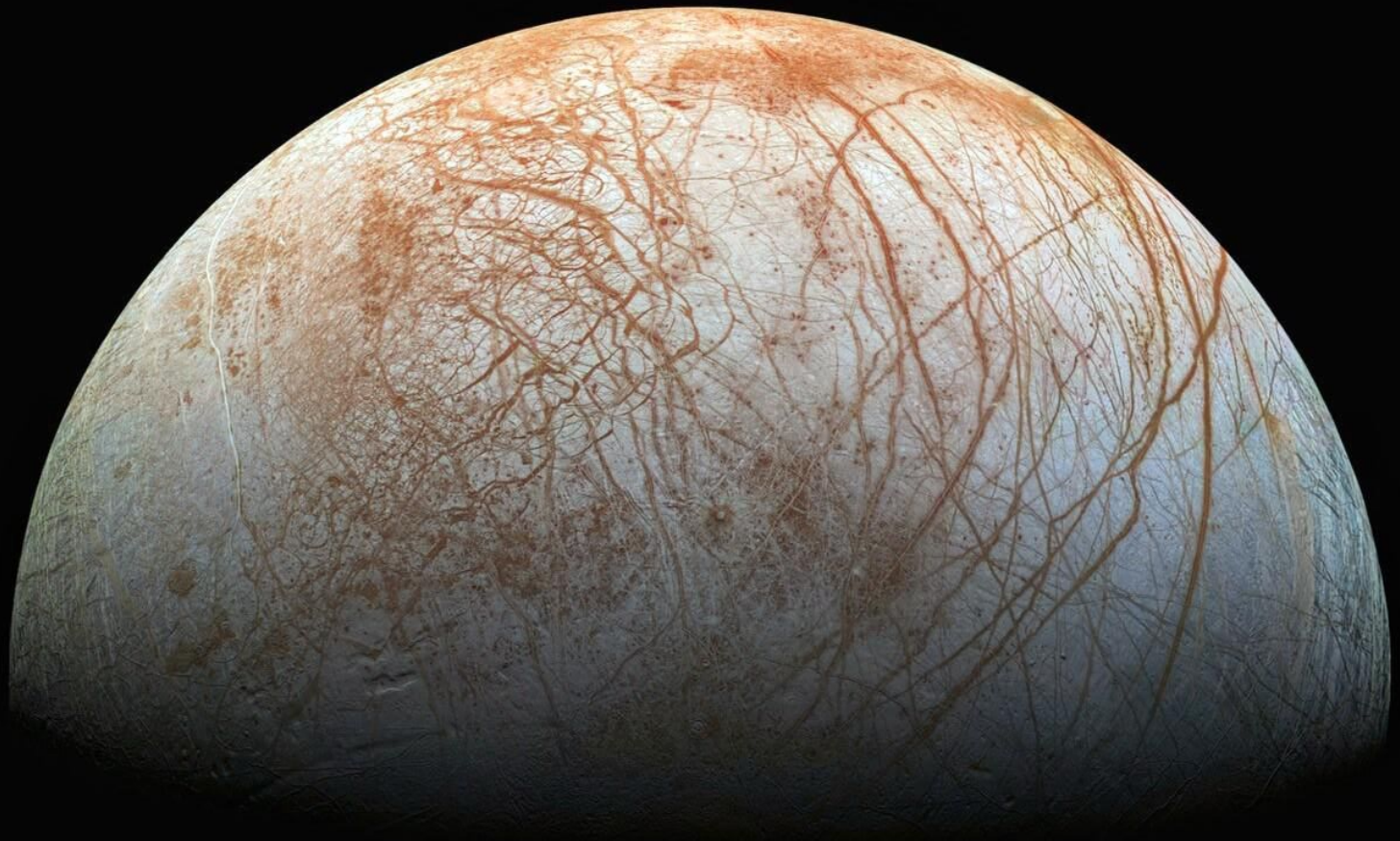
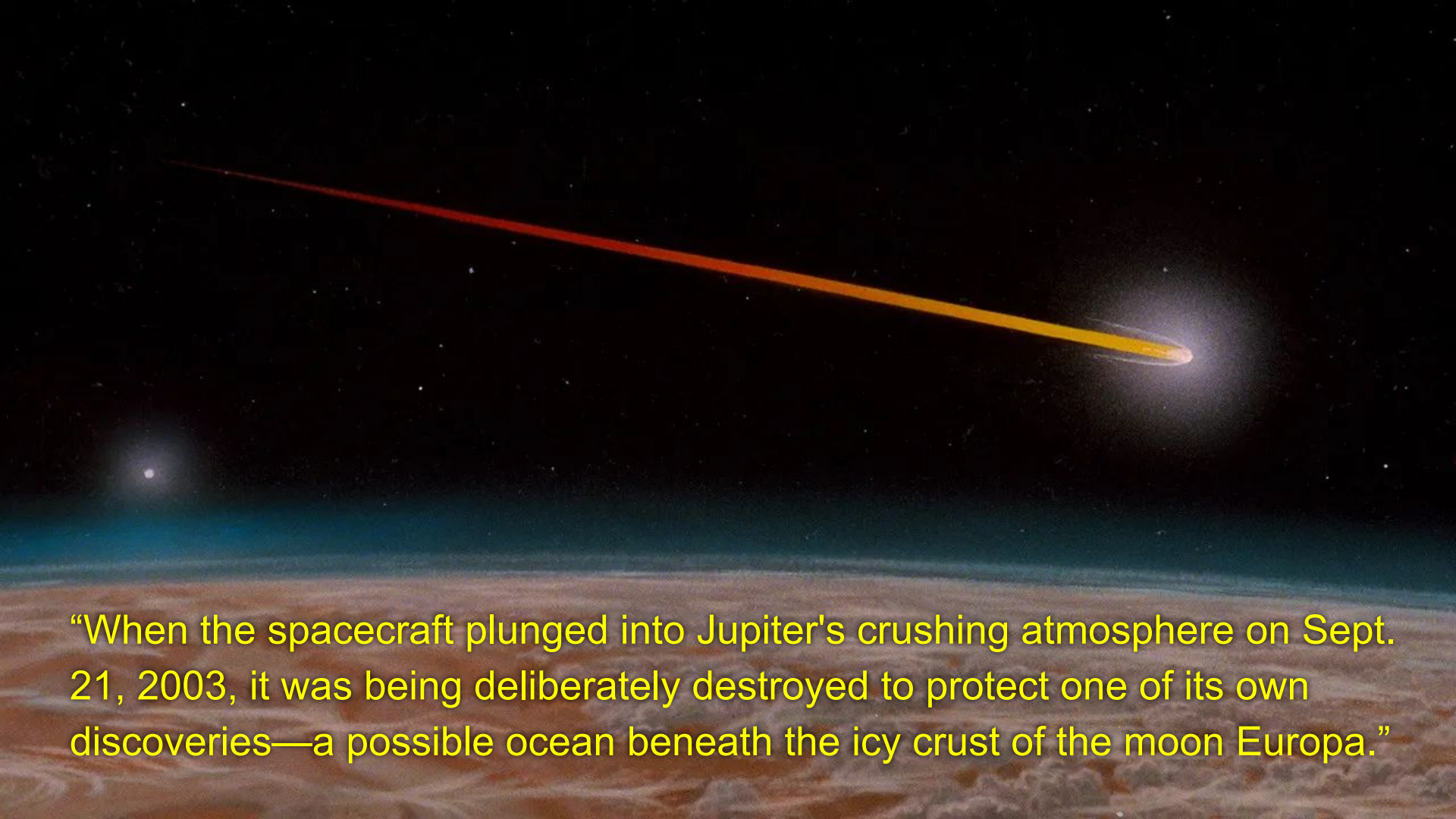




“When the spacecraft plunged into Jupiter's crushing atmosphere on Sept. 21, 2003, it was being deliberately destroyed to protect one of its own discoveries—a possible ocean beneath the icy crust of the moon Europa.”

Protecting our Solar System:

Planetary Protection and the Future of Space Exploration

"The practice of protecting solar system bodies from contamination by Earth life."

COSPAR
COMMITTEE ON SPACE RESEARCH

Space Park Leicester
UNOOSA
esa
NASA
UK SPACE AGENCY
Natural History Museum
AstrobiologyOU
The Open University

Takeaway

- **Biological interdependence & Human centered**
  - What we do to the environment affects ourselfs.
- **Global significance**
  - The effect can not be blocked by border.
- **Longtermism**
  - The effect are not blocked by time neither.

Even before the rise of the modern environmental movement, there were pioneering ideas that were more ecocentric (such as land ethics), but the mainstream public environmental agenda was more **shallow ecology**.

9.4 Deep Ecology vs Shallow Ecology

Definition:

Ecology: the branch of biology that deals with the relations of organisms to one another and to their physical surroundings.

Organism: an individual animal, plant, or single-celled life form.

Physical surrounding:

- Built Environment:Infrastructure, buildings, room, and furniture…
- Natural Elements: Geography, climate, air quality…
- Atmosphere: Lighting, temperature, sound…

Shallow Ecology:

In the book:

Shallow: “a fight against pollution and resource depletion”

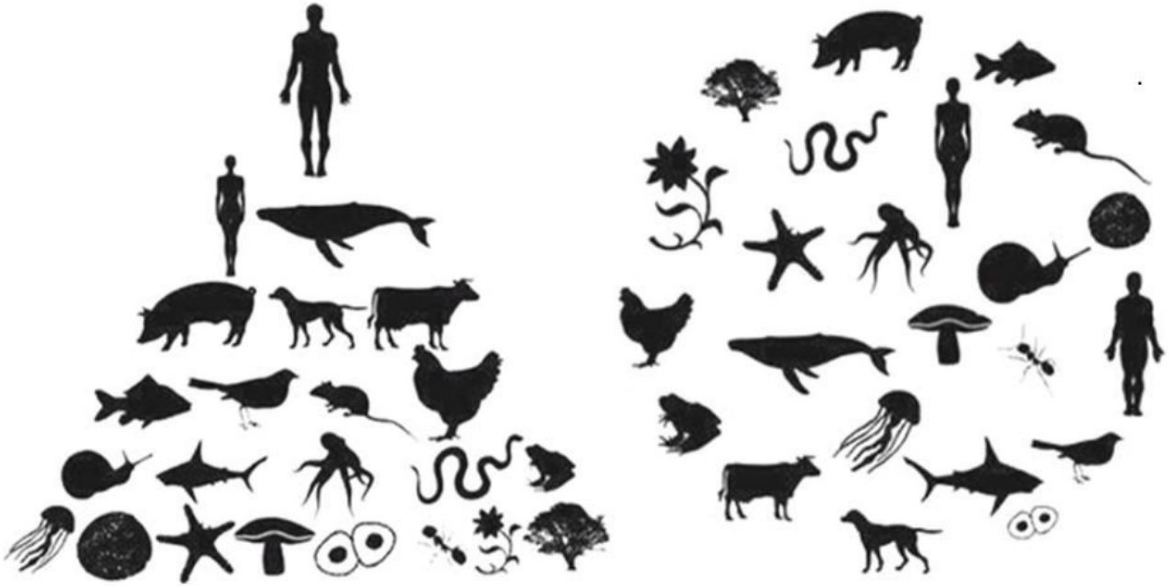
- Cares about the environment because it impacts human health and well-being.
- Its value logic is: protecting the environment → protecting human interests (instrumental/tool-like value) → Therefore, humanity needs to take responsibility for the environment.
- Anthropocentrism: regarding humankind as the central or most important element of existence
- It grounds respect for nature on human interests

Deep Ecology:

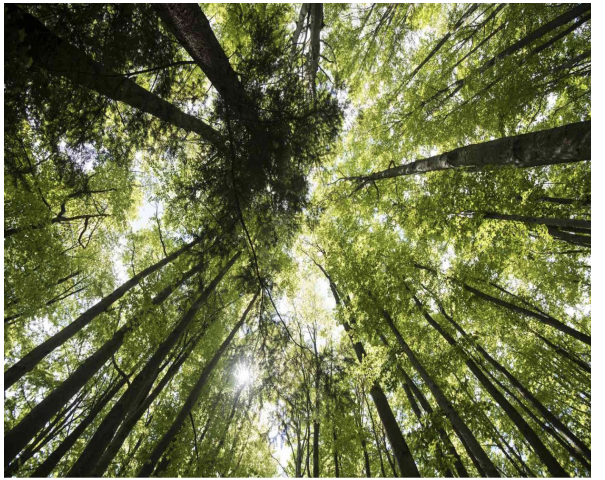
Quote from the book: “a genuinely ecocentric interest in the future and well-being of the planet”

- The key claim of Deep Ecology is that nature/planet itself is not a "resource to serve humanity," but rather an object worthy of respect.
- It attempts to establish intrinsic value: nature "has value in itself," not because it is useful to humans. Humankind respects its intrinsic value.
- Ecocentrism: an environmental philosophy that places intrinsic, nature-centered value on the entire ecosystem—including landscapes, species, and ecological processes—rather than focusing solely on human interests

Deep and Shallow Ecology



Try to build new values: Biodiversity, Sustainability, and Natural beauty.



Do these three things equal Deep Ecology?

Environmental Value	Real-World Example	Human-Centered Reason
Biodiversity	Protecting bees because they pollinate crops such as apples, and blueberries.	It benefits agriculture and medicine.
Sustainability	Limiting fishing quotas to prevent the collapse of fish populations	It preserves natural resources for future generations.
Natural Beauty	Protecting national parks like from mining or industrial development.	People value scenic landscapes and enjoy experiencing them.

Takeaway:

- Environmental values often cited by deep ecology include biodiversity, sustainability, and natural beauty. However, these values can often still be explained in terms of human interests (food supply, long-term resources)
- It is difficult to establish a truly non-human-centered environmental ethic. Many arguments that seem to support deep ecology may actually remain forms of shallow ecology.
- Even so, humanity should still learn to respect the existence of nature itself and accept it.

9.6 Nature and Gaia

What can provide a deeper foundation for environmental ethics?

Deep ecology introduces another idea: **The Sublime**

It appeals to **human emotional response to nature**:

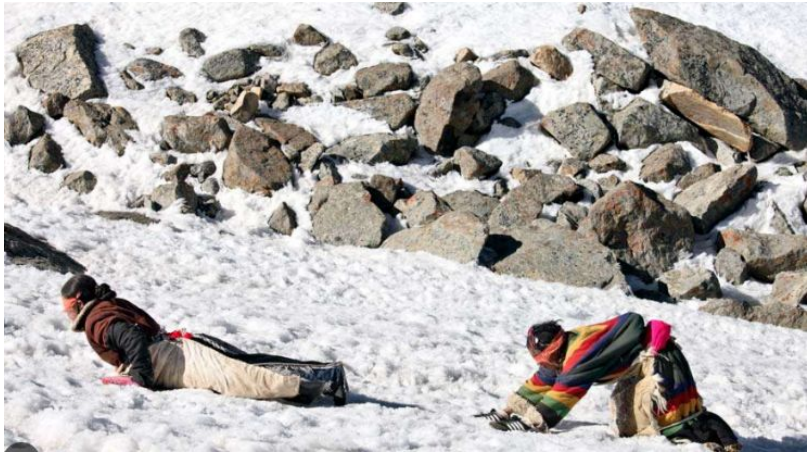
Awe fear respect

Bernard Williams calls this: **Promethean fear**

Mount Kailash (Tibet)

Mount Kailash is regarded as a **sacred mountain** and the **center of the world** in several religious traditions.

It is considered holy in four religions: Tibetan Buddhism Hinduism Bön jainism



Pilgrims perform a ritual known as **kora** (circumambulation), walking around the mountain. The full route is about **52 km**. Some devotees complete the journey through **full-body prostrations**, which may take many days.

They do not visit the mountain for tourism, but out of: **awe reverence fear a sense of sacredness**

Gaia Hypothesis

Proposed by: James Lovelock (1979)

Main idea: Earth functions as a **self-regulating system** and behaves **like a living organism**

Different components interact: atmosphere oceans soil living organisms

Together they regulate: climate chemical balance conditions for life

Lovelock's opinion

If Gaia is a self-regulating system:

Humans are only **one part of the system and** earth may survive **without humans**

Lovelock suggests: The real danger is not to Gaia, but to human civilization.

Earth has survived with climate change, mass extinctions, geological disasters for **billions of years**.

Author’s thought

Can the Gaia hypothesis truly serve as the ethical foundation of deep ecology?

If yes, then what is our reason for protecting the environment?

If the reason is simply: Humanity will become extinct then it's still: Anthropocentrism

brings us back to shallow ecology.

Daoist Ideas and Deep Ecology

Daoist philosophy expresses a similar view of nature.

Key ideas include:

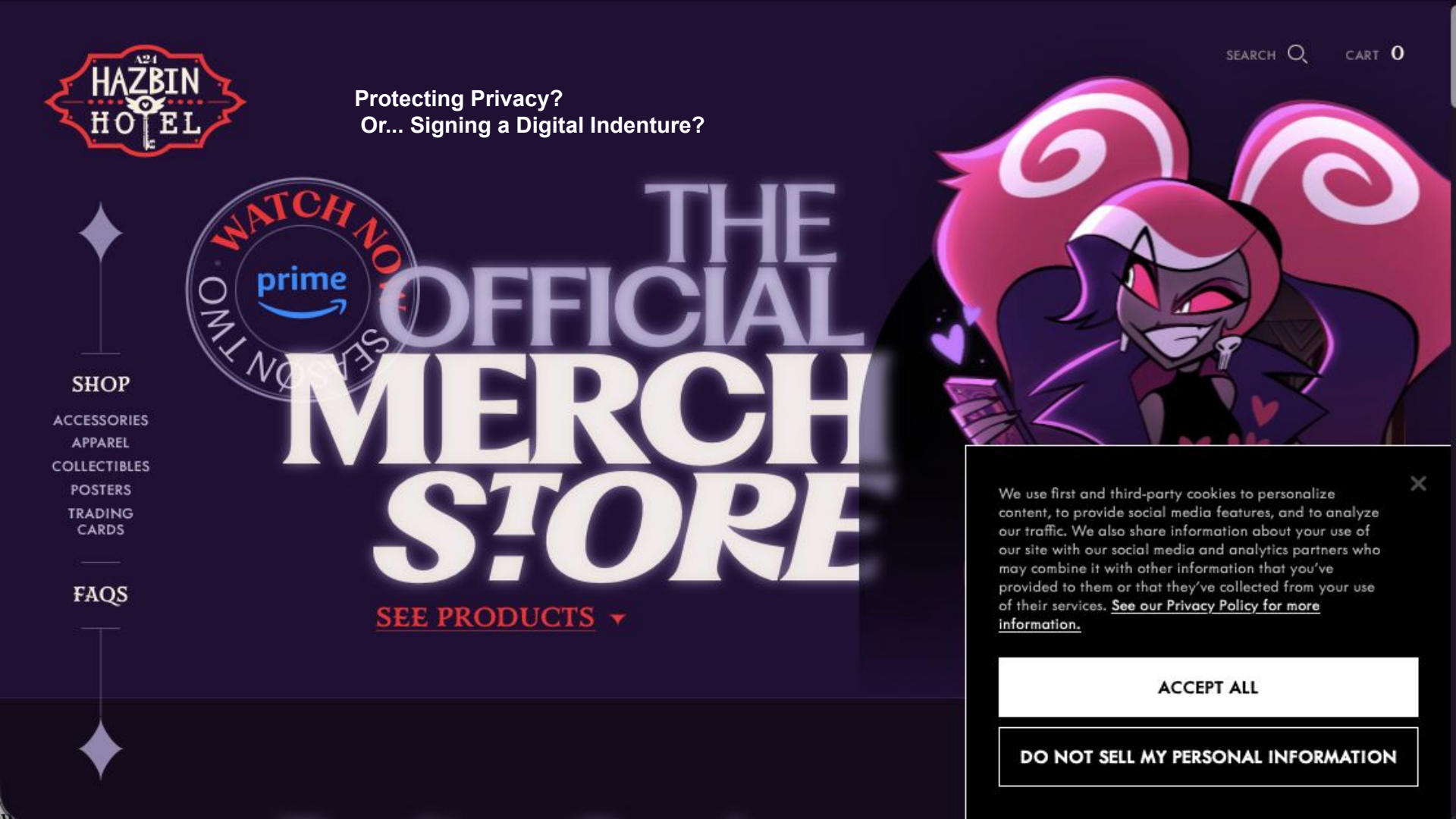
- **Dao follows nature**
  Humans should follow the natural order.

- **Wu Wei**
  Act in harmony with nature rather than dominate it.

- **Unity of Heaven and Humanity**
  Humans and nature are part of the same whole.

These ideas are very similar to the deep ecology view that humans are **part of the ecological system**.

Protecting Privacy?
Or... Signing a Digital Indenture?



At a Dangerous Crossroads

A Dystopia Ruled by Tech Oligarchs

Technological Neutrality

Are machines truly free of bias?

'the algorithm decided' or 'data doesn't lie.'

Who writes the code? Who funds the development?

“Therefore, safeguarding the integrity of the vote can only be accomplished through educational means rather than through virtual coercion, whether in the form of punishment (e.g., penalizing bad behavior)or reward (e.g., accumulation of extrinsic perceived happiness).”

collapse of our autonomy

Good Old Days

Society was more civilized？？？

Technology was simply incapable of breaching it.

surveillance technology becomes omnipotent

What is True Privacy?

Not just hiding from surveillance.

A Personal Sanctuary to incubate diversity, void of judgment and conformity.

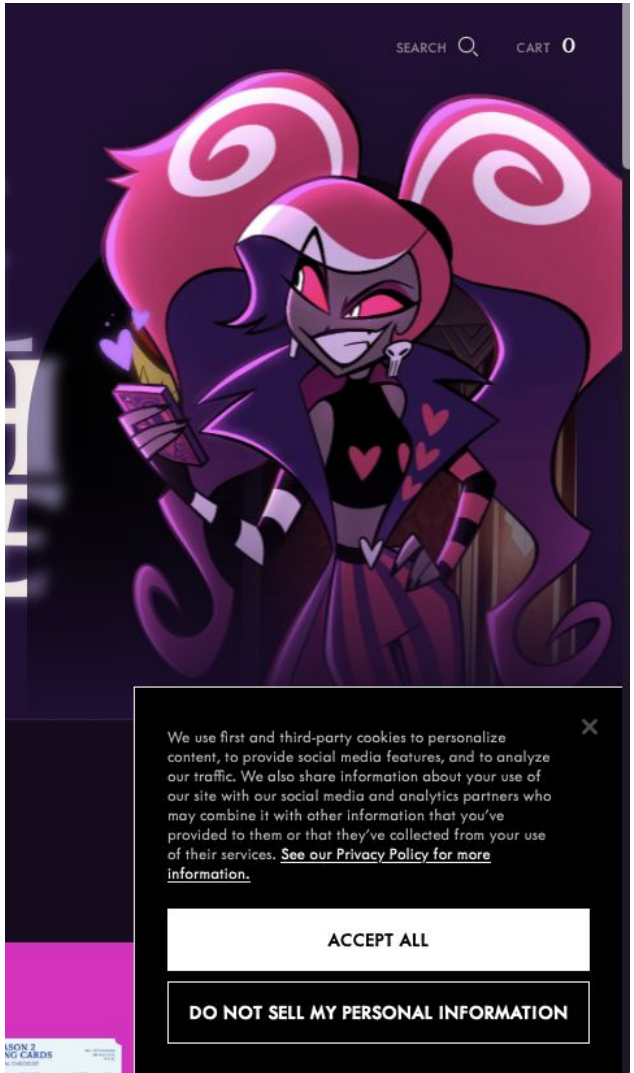
Without privacy, society becomes totally transparent. And in a transparent society, everyone acts the same. We lose the soil for human diversity and voluntarily degrade ourselves into identical, compliant machines.

The Privacy Law Trap

"Do you consent to our terms?"

we have Privacy Acts! We have GDPR!

They are merely a framework to legitimize the process of invading your privacy.



Accountability Collapses When Legitimacy Is Unchecked

Why do decentralized, accountable platforms like Blockchain ？

We are digital subjects by choice.(We voluntarily accept their laws because they are convenient.)

Accountability Collapses doesn’t because the tech is broken; it fails because we have stopped questioning the right of these institutions to rule us.

Takeaway

1. BEYOND THE NEUTRALITY MYTH Algorithms are NOT objective; they are extensions of human subjectivity. Bias is built-in.

2. PRIVACY AS A SANCTUARY Privacy is the soil for human diversity. Without it, we are forced into a world of conformity.

3. QUESTION LEGITIMACY We must stop the cycle of 'Voluntary Compliance.' Convenience is a trap when it leads to blind obedience. Technology only becomes an authoritarian force when we stop questioning its legitimacy.

4. EDUCATION OVER COERCION True reform starts with education. We cannot fix a moral crisis with more code or stricter punishments. We must nurture 'Intrinsic Values' through education, ensuring that technology serves humanity, and not the other way around.